

National Coverage Determination (NCD)

Acupuncture for Osteoarthritis

30.3.2

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Tracking Information

Publication Number

100-3

Manual Section Number

30.3.2

Manual Section Title

Acupuncture for Osteoarthritis

Version Number

2

Effective Date of this Version

01/21/2020

Implementation Date

06/24/2020

Description Information

Benefit Category

Incident to a physician's professional Service

Inpatient Hospital Services

Physicians' Services

Please Note: This may not be an exhaustive list of all applicable Medicare benefit categories for this item or service.

Item/Service Description**A. General**

Acupuncture is the selection and manipulation of specific acupuncture points by a variety of needling and non-needling techniques.

Indications and Limitations of Coverage

B. Nationally Covered Indications

N/A for acupuncture for osteoarthritis.

C. Nationally Non-Covered Indications

Effective for claims with dates of service on and after April 16, 2004, after careful reconsideration of its initial non-coverage determination for acupuncture, the Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS) concludes that there is no convincing evidence for the use of acupuncture for pain relief in patients with osteoarthritis. Study design flaws presently prohibit assessing acupuncture's utility for improving health outcomes. Accordingly, CMS determines that acupuncture is not considered reasonable and necessary for the treatment of osteoarthritis within the meaning of §1862(a)(1) of the Social Security Act, and the national non-coverage determination for acupuncture for osteoarthritis continues.

D. Other

N/A

(This NCD last reviewed April 2004.)

Claims Processing Instructions

[TN 10128 \(Medicare Claims Processing\)](#) 

Transmittal Information

Transmittal Number

10128

Coverage Transmittal Link

<https://www.cms.gov/files/document/r10128NCD.pdf> 

Revision History

05/2020 - The purpose of this change request is to inform MACs that CMS will cover acupuncture for chronic low back pain (cLBP) effective for claims with dates of service on and after January 21, 2020. ([TN 10128](#) ) (CR 11755)

04/2004 - Noncoverage for acupuncture continued. Effective and implementation dates 04/16/2004. ([TN 11](#)) (CR 3250)

National Coverage Analyses (NCAs)

This NCD has been or is currently being reviewed under the National Coverage Determination process. The following are existing associations with NCAs, from the National Coverage Analyses database.

- [Original Consideration for Acupuncture for Osteoarthritis \(CAG-00175N\)](#)

Additional Information

Other Versions

Title	Version	Effective Between	
Acupuncture for Osteoarthritis	2	01/21/2020 - N/A	You are here
Acupuncture for Osteoarthritis	1	04/16/2004 - 01/21/2020	View